Ledge

By William Borden

INTRODUCTION

TOM: *People are always talking about living life on the edge.*
MARY: *I don't think they ever really meant what they said but…*
BOTH: I'm a literal thinker.
TOM: *And the closest thing to the edge is the…*
MARY: *"Ledge" by William Borden.*

(Lights come up to reveal MARY standing on the ledge of a building, her back pressed against the building, looking straight ahead, and inching away from an open window. She thinks for a moment. Then she starts to inch back toward the window -just as TOM climbs out of the window onto the ledge.)

TOM: This is my ledge.

MARY: I was here first.

TOM: I suppose you made a reservation.

MARY: If you're going to jump, jump.

TOM: Of course I'm going to jump! *(Several beats)* You were here first.

MARY: Go ahead.

TOM: You go.

MARY: No, you go.

TOM: You.

MARY: *Jump!*

TOM: All right. *(He adjusts his position. He readjusts.)* You're crowding me.

MARY: I'm sorry!

TOM: Could you ... *(She edges away, giving him room. She slips. He grabs her.)*

MARY: Thanks. *(He readies himself He stops.)*

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TOM: How's it going to look?

MARY: Messy.

TOM: My going first. Who'll pay attention to me, with you still up here, making a spectacle of yourself? They'll just step over me - what's left of me - and they'll be shining spotlights on you and sending reporters out to interview you and I'll be lucky to be a sidebar on the comics page, which is the story of my life. So go on. *(She looks down. Cars honk.)* You climbed out here. *(She gathers her courage.)* You made a decision. *(She readies herself)* You knew there was no reason to put up with it any longer. *(She's ready.)* Stop! *(She stops.)* You jump first, who'll pay any attention to me, up here, a speck on the forty-first floor? You'll get all the attention, as usual.

MARY: As usual?

TOM: You women. You're always getting the attention. With your legs. Your breasts. Your emotions. Get off.

MARY: Off?

TOM: Through the window.

MARY: You're between me and the window.

TOM: There must be another window around the corner.

MARY: I might fall.

TOM: All right then, jump. I'll wait until they've scraped you up and carried you away in a shoebox, then I'll call attention to myself. Go on, go on, get it over with.

MARY: I'll jump when I'm good and ready.

TOM: *Jump!*

MARY: *No! (Tom pulls out a gun and aims it at her.)* Shoot. *(Tom smiles, puts away*

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the gun.)

TOM: You women think you're so clever, so damned clever! Tom Longmyer, murderer? No, no. You can borrow it, if you like.

MARY: Why would I want your gun?

TOM: You could make sure that way.

MARY: Forty-one stories is sure.

TOM: I was going to use the revolver, but ...

MARY: What?

TOM: I was afraid nobody would notice. A shot, drowned out by the bedlam of the city. Shots all the time! Gang warfare, drug dealers. Buses make a lot of noise, too. You can't hear yourself think.

MARY: I've never heard myself think. I mean, you think very quietly, really. Silently, in fact. Don't you?

TOM: It's just an expression!

MARY: But words should mean something. Don't you think?

TOM: *(He pulls the gun again.)* Get off my ledge.

MARY: You are so insignificant.

TOM: Don't say that to me.

MARY: Nothing. An absence.

TOM: Don't say that to me!

MARY: Who will miss you? *(He begins to cry. She watches him coldly for a moment.)* I'm sorry. *(He bawls.)* I'm sorry! *(He wails.)* I'm sorry, Tom! *(He stops abruptly, smiles.)* Give me the gun. *(He hands her the gun.)*

TOM: Be careful. The safety's on.

MARY: How do you turn it off? *(He switches off the safety.)*

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TOM: In the mouth. Blows the brains right out. The temple - the bullet can ricochet off the inside of your skull, leave you a semiconscious vegetable for the rest of your life. *(She aims the revolver at him.)* What are you doing?

MARY: You manipulated me.

TOM: You shoot me, they'll send you to the chair.

MARY: I don't care.

TOM: You wouldn't dare.

MARY: Wouldn't I?

TOM: You women

MARY: You men.

TOM: - Always flaunting yourselves

MARY: You're all the same!

TOM: All you want is a love slave!

MARY: Manipulator!

TOM: Show-off! *(She pulls the trigger. The hammer clicks. She pulls it several more times.)*

TOM: I didn't have the guts.

MARY: You're a zero.

TOM: I'm not worth your pity.

MARY: You're disgusting!

TOM: I'm not even that significant.

MARY: Get off my ledge!

TOM: My ledge!

MARY: Mine!

TOM: Minemineminemine!

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MARY: You're so juvenile. *(She tries to edge around him, to get to the window.)*

TOM: What are you doing?

MARY: You've spoiled it.

TOM: Be careful. You might fall.

MARY: Fat lot you care, Tom Longmyer.

TOM: But aren't you going to ...?

MARY: I don't have to put up with you on the day I'm going to die. I can at least have some privacy. Some quality time to myself as I prepare to ... you know. *(She can't get around him.)* You climb around me.

TOM: You climb around me.

MARY: Come on, I'm getting cold.

TOM: I might fall.

MARY: Climb around me or I'll push you off. *(He tries, he loses hisbalance, she pulls him back. They're belly to belly, face to face. He flings himself back to the building, where he was before, between her and the window.)* You're just like my father! Cowardly, weak, ineffectual!

TOM: If you're so effectual, be my guest. *(He motions her to climb around him.)*

MARY: It's too windy.

TOM: You are so effectual. *(She flings herself before him, grabbing at the building. He holds her.)*

MARY: Let go. *(He lets go. She starts to fall. He grabs her. They're both precarious.)*

TOM: You hold onto the building, I'll hold onto you. *(They do. Several beats)* I've never been this close to a woman before. Without kissing her.

MARY: Kiss me and I'll jump and take you with me.

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TOM: You had coffee for breakfast.

MARY: Do I have bad breath? I have mints somewhere ... *(She reaches for her mints, teeters, he hauls her in, their lips brush.)*

TOM: I didn't kiss you! It was an accident! Just a brush ... of lips...hardly noticeable... like me ...

MARY: You should have shaved. Your death day, the least you could have done

TOM: Who's going to tell, me smeared on the boulevard like sauce on a pizza?

MARY: If you took a little pride in yourself...

TOM: ... I wouldn't be here. *(Several beats)*

MARY: Tom ...

TOM: I don't even know your name.

MARY: Mary. Tom ...

TOM: Mary what?

MARY: Mary Freestone. Tom ... *(He kisses her - a long kiss. She kisses him - tenderly, for a long time. They catch their breaths.)* You're excited.

TOM: I know.

MARY: Well stop it. *(Several beats)*

TOM: I can't. *(Several beats)* Mary?

MARY: What?

TOM: I don't want to die.

MARY: You should have planned ahead a little better.

TOM: Do you?

MARY: I don't care.

TOM: Well, then you should move, so if one of us falls, it's you.

MARY: I mean, I don't care if *you* die. I care if *I* die.

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TOM: I'm losing my erection.

MARY: That gives us more room.

TOM: Mary? I want you to live, too.

MARY: That's nice. *(She succeeds in getting around him. She inches toward the window.)*

TOM: Don't leave me! Mary!

MARY: Don't be a crybaby.

TOM: *(Crying)* I don't want to die.

MARY: Why did you come out here if you don't want to die?!

TOM: I hadn't met you.

MARY: You're trying to manipulate me.

TOM: If that's true, I'll kill myself! *(She waits.)* You want me to jump, just for a tiny manipulation? *(She waits. He starts to jump.)*

MARY: Give me your hand.

TOM: You don't think I have the integrity to jump? *(He really starts to jump.)*

MARY: Just give me your hand. *(He clutches her hand. They edge to the window. The window, which is barred, falls shut.)*

TOM: What is it?

MARY: The window fell shut.

TOM: Open it.

MARY: It locks automatically. *(They look at each other.)*

TOM AND MARY: Help!

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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